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A 2020 perspective on "How live streaming influences purchase intentions in social commerce: An IT affordance perspective"

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ABSTRACT

Live-streaming shopping has become increasingly popular in social commerce. Reviewing recent research on live-streaming shopping, we find that most papers about this topic have focused on user behavior and user experience. While these previous studies, including Sun et al. (2019), have provided useful insights into different aspects of live-streaming in social commerce, most of them have used cross-sectional surveys as the primary research method. Therefore, limitations such as the self-reporting bias or the common research method bias may hinder our understanding of the real effect of live-streaming on consumer purchase behavior. The actual causal relationship between live-streaming and consumer purchases should be further examined using more robust econometric models, natural experiments, or longitudinal studies.

Live-streaming shopping, a new form of social commerce, has recently been integrated into social business and media platforms, such as Taobao and Facebook. Through the live-streaming shopping function, sellers can use real-video to present products and interact with potential buyers. Consumers can also express their opinions and post their comments on a real-time basis. In our recent work (Sun et al., 2019), we developed a theoretical model of IT affordance to explain why customers like to interact with buyers and how interaction influences consumer purchase attention. Three dimensions of IT affordance are identified, including visibility, *meta*-voicing, and shopping guidance.

However, the new marketing tool's influence on business transactions and consumer behavior has not been fully understood. In the past two years, we have witnessed keen interest in live-streaming shopping research because of its increasing popularity. Many researchers have investigated different aspects of it. For example, Cai and Wohn (2019) examined the intrinsic motivation of buyers' engagement in live-streaming from using gratifications perspective. Wang and Wu (2019) conceptualized three user engagement mechanisms, including product interactivity, communication immediacy, and peer cues associated with a live streaming platform. They explored how these mechanisms can improve user product evaluation and their serendipity to explore more products. Zhou et al. (2019) investigated the role of viewers social interaction in paid gifting on live streaming platforms. They found that living screen comments can motivate potential buyers' paid gifting behavior.

In addition, Guo et al. (2019) identified two living video presenters' characteristics: screen presence and powerful emotions. They learned that these were positively related to viewership engagement outcomes. Moreover, Park and Lin (2020) proposed that Internet celebrities have a positive effect on attracting viewers and increasing the possibility of purchases. Using a qualitative analysis, Diwanji et al. (2020) provided theoretical insights into understanding human behavior on a living-streaming platform.

These previous studies have provided useful insights into different aspects of live-streaming in social commerce (e.g., intrinsic motivation, the interaction mechanism, and consequences). However, we need to point out that most of these studies only employ simple descriptive analysis, text analysis or correlation analysis. A cross-sectional survey is the primary research method used in many of these studies. Therefore, some limitations such as self-reporting bias and common research method bias may hinder our understanding of the real effect of live-streaming on consumer purchase behavior. The actual causal relationship between live-streaming and consumer behavior should be further examined using robust econometric models, natural experiments, or longitudinal studies.

Besides, to analyze the interactive content of live-streaming, future studies can consider adopting natural language processing techniques and deep learning networks. For example, using real transaction data

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and a *difference-in-difference* (DiD) casual inference modeling, we can identify the control group (i.e., sellers without using the living stream function) and the treatment group (i.e., sellers using the living stream function) and compare the differences in their transaction behavior. In a related research project, we are studying the formation mechanism of *swift guanxi*, a quickly-developed kind of personal social rapport between customers and streamers, aiming to better understand the impact of live-streaming on consumer purchase decisions.

In sum, we believe that more rigorous empirical methods are needed to examine the role of live-streaming in improving consumer engagement and motivation in the context of social commerce.

Declaration of Competing Interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

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